
Personal Integrity and Bernard Lonergan's General Transcendent Knowledge

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Bernard Lonergan (1904-1984), more than 35 years ago, wrote that cultural change demands «the development of a new theological method and style, [...] *meeting all the genuine exigencies* both of the Christian religion and of *up-to-date philosophy*, science, and scholarship».¹ One of the major achievements of Lonergan's philosophy is the achievement of the fourfold human (or philosophical) differentiated consciousness, which he later integrated into his theological method. This certainly is significant, and it is one of the major achievements of Lonergan's *Insight* (1957). However, if this were the only achievement, the particular philosophical positions of the book would not be interesting (unless for historical reasons). Nevertheless, there seems to be several important philosophical positions worthy of consideration, although some of them may need further elaboration and sometimes a reformulation in a more up-to-date terminology.

In the paper, we will explore Lonergan's «general transcendent knowledge», at the center of which is his argument for the existence of God. What makes Lonergan's proof distinct from the others is the starting point (the self-affirmation), the core epistemic exigency of the search for a complete explanation, the affirmation of the complete intelligibility of reality, and his concept of God (the unrestricted act of understanding). Lonergan always maintained the validity of his argument, even though he later said that it ignores the horizon within which the argument can be effective.

We will start with a few preliminary ideas about the value of the argument in Lonergan's system and in philosophical theology in general. Next, a brief reconstruction of the argument from *Insight* will follow. Several different interpretations and objections against its validity will require a further elaboration of a few key statements. Even though somebody may not accept the argument as deductively valid, it will become apparent that personal cognitive integrity calls for the development of the systematic philosophical theolo-

¹ B. LONERGAN, «Doctrinal Pluralism (1971)» in *Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan (CWL)* 17, Toronto, 2004, 85-86. Italics mine.

gy, and at the same time that Lonergan's recognition, affirmation, and acceptance of God requires an authentic, unbiased human knower. Several further features of Lonergan's philosophical theology will emerge. Some familiarity with Lonergan's philosophy will be presupposed.

The Importance of the Argument

A great number of scholars agree that the existence of God has to be reasonably well justified, before one accepts the creed of any religion.² Good reasons for believing in the existence of God make an important part of intellectual integrity of any theologian or Christian philosopher. In the absence of a rational proof, they might still have good reasons (social and/or historical) for believing in God, but something important would be missing. Probably the most extreme expression of such a requirement (of Evidentialist challenge) we find in the writings of W. K. Clifford:

Religious beliefs must be founded in evidence; if they are not so founded, it is wrong to hold them. The rule of right conduct in this matter is exactly the opposite of that implied in the two most famous texts: «He that believeth not shall be damned» [Mark 16:16], and «Blessed are they that have not seen and yet have believed» [John 20:29]. For a man who clearly felt and recognized the duty of intellectual honesty, of testing every belief before he receives it, and especially before he recommended it to others, it would be impossible to ascribe the profoundly immoral teaching of these texts to a true prophet or worthy leader of humanity. [...] But whoever wrote either of them down [...] has thereby written down himself as a man void of intellectual honesty, as a man whose word cannot be trusted, as a man who would accept and spread about any kind of baseless fiction for fear of believing too little.³

Clifford does not give us a satisfactory explanation what would count as a sufficient evidence, but his statement illustrates well the importance of the rational arguments for the existence of God in our culture.

When Lonergan writes about «immanently generated knowledge» in

² Cardinal Schönborn says: «Faith without a rational justification is not a faith, but only an illusion» (Ch. SCHÖNBORN, «Rozumná veda, rozumná viera» in *Impulz* 3 [2007] 38). Similarly: W.K. Clifford, A. Kenny, A. Flew, R. Swinburne. Some of them (A. Flew) say that without a good argument we have to be atheist (assumption of atheism), and some others (B. Russell, A. Kenny) that we should be agnostic.

³ W.K. CLIFFORD, «The Ethics of Religion» in S. T. JOSHI (ed.), *The Agnostic Reader*, Amherst - New York, 2007, 243.

Insight, he means generation of new concepts and/or theories, and reasonable judgments about their truthfulness. Such a knowledge includes the grasp of the «virtually unconditioned», which means, that one understands the conditions of something being true and concludes that the conditions happen to be fulfilled. From the overall content of *Insight*, we can deduce that the achievement of the immanently generated knowledge of the existence of God is, according to Lonergan, possible and necessary.

Later in *Philosophy of God, and Theology* (1974), Lonergan said that the origin of the philosophy of God is in religious experience (the root of which is in God's gift of his love), and that «it is only in the climate of religious experience that philosophy of God flourishes».⁴ At this point, let us distinguish Lonergan's later philosophy of God, which is better called philosophy of religion, from philosophical theology. The latter concerns systematic analysis of the concept and the existence of God. Conceptual and systematic thinking is decisive in the arguments of philosophical theology. It was the major concern of the first Lonergan in *Insight*, and it was later developed by B. Tyrrell⁵ and H. Meynell⁶ at length. Philosophy of religion understood as philosophical thinking about religion covers a broader spectrum of questions regarding existing religions, among which the questions of religious experience, conversion, and culture are some of the most important. Jim Kanaris⁷ developed the conception of religious experience and philosophy of religions at length as intended by the second Lonergan.

According to later Lonergan, philosophical theology and the arguments, in which one tries to be precise in the use of terms and logic, belong rather to the context of classicism or scholasticism and conceptualism, than to contemporary pluralist culture.⁸ He realized that the cultural change made scholastic approach, and thus traditional philosophical theology, no longer relevant. Nonetheless, even though scholastic objectivism may already be old fashioned and not very interesting for Lonergan and some of his fellows, it is important for his philosophy. He says:

The development of philosophic and scientific systems profoundly affects a culture. But if it modifies the outlook of most of the members in the culture, still it does not do so by transforming them into systematic thinkers. Systematic thinkers are

⁴ B. LONERGAN, *Philosophy of God, and Theology*, Philadelphia, 1973, 55.

⁵ B. TYRRELL, *Bernard Lonergan's Philosophy of God*, Notre Dame, 1974.

⁶ H. A. MEYNELL, *The Intelligible Universe: A Cosmological Argument*, Totowa (N.J.), 1982.

⁷ J. KANARIS, *Bernard Lonergan's Philosophy of Religion. From Philosophy of God to Philosophy of Religious Studies*, New York, 2002.

⁸ See B. LONERGAN, *Philosophy of God, and Theology*, IX.

relatively rare. But their achievement is diffused by the commentators, the teachers, the popularizers that illuminate, complete, transpose, simplify.⁹

Even in the recent times, we witness a rise of several «popularizers» who have taken up deep atheistic ideas of the past, and several systematic thinkers who argue for improbability or even impossibility of the existence of God.

In regard to the arguments, Lonergan says: «I do not think it difficult to establish God's existence. I do think it a life-long labor to analyze and refute all the objections that philosophers have thought up against the existence of God».¹⁰ Lonergan may be right about the life-long labor, but if it takes all life to refute the objections, it does not seem easy to show that God exists. For the arguments are not only for believers to strengthen their faith, but they also are expected to show faults in the argumentation of atheists and agnostics. Responses to the most significant objections make integral part of philosophical theology and argumentation.

In regard to the acceptance of the existence of God, Lonergan is right that a fully human acceptance requires a triple (intellectual, moral, and religious) conversion, and the root of the religious conversion is experience of God's love. Its importance was another reason why Lonergan became more interested in the conversion/transformation of an authentic subject than in «objectivist», or systematic, philosophical reflections about the existence of God. This is also the reason why his argument in *Insight* is somehow unfinished and little bit sketchy (and «it may seem too rapid»¹¹). It does not mean, however, that the argument somehow presupposes a conversion. Lonergan expects «authentic subjectivity» in the sense of «self-transcendence towards objectivity»; in other words, readiness for intellectual conversion when good reasons for a change of position arise.

When Lonergan writes about personal integrity in *Method in Theology*, he means integration of different departments of knowing: «Development is through specialization but it must end in integration».¹² Personal integrity also calls for «reconciliation of truth and value, and so of science as concerned for truth with religion as concerned for value».¹³ The basis of such integrity is human self-transcendence towards objective value and true good (not only apparent truth and good). Cognitive authenticity means self-transcendence in knowing: «it [self-transcendence] not merely goes beyond the

⁹ *Ibid.*, 8.

¹⁰ *Ibid.*, 55.

¹¹ B. LONERGAN, *Insight*, in *CWL* 03, 679.

¹² *Id.*, *Method in Theology*, London, 1972, 140.

¹³ *Id.*, «Horizons» in *CWL* 17, 13.

subject but also seeks what is independent of the subject. For a judgment that this or that really is so reports, not what appears to me, not what I imagine, not what I think, not what I would be inclined to say, not what seems to be so, but what is so». ¹⁴ This is why personal cognitive integrity requires an objective justification of the existence of God and development of the specialization in a systematic philosophical theology.

Lonergan's Argument for the Existence of God

Lonergan starts with the question of «What is being?» First, he defines and analyzes the notion of being, and he deduces the concept of an unrestricted act of understanding (God) from his analysis of human knowing, especially from the unrestricted desire to know. It is only in the next sections, where he asks «What is causality?» and says that with this question «we shall be lead to affirm that there is such an unrestricted act». ¹⁵ Subsequently, he distinguishes external causes (efficient, final, and exemplary) and internal causes (central and conjugate potency, form, and act). ¹⁶ External causes are somehow anthropomorphic, since they are conceived analogously with the purposive human actions within the realm of the proportionate being. ¹⁷ The question is whether they hold in general for the proportionate being as a whole. Lonergan explains that there are deeper metaphysical principles capable of bearing human knowledge from the realm of proportionate being to the realm of transcendent being. In his argument, Lonergan establishes that being is intelligible and the universe of proportionate being is incompletely intelligible. He adds an epistemic exigency of the search for a complete explanation.

According to Lonergan, all the arguments for the existence of God are included in the following general form of affirmation: «If the real is completely intelligible, God exists. But the real is completely intelligible. Therefore, God exists». ¹⁸ A longer formulation: «If the real is completely intelligible, then complete intelligibility exists. If complete intelligibility exists, the idea of being exists. If the idea of being exists, then God exists». ¹⁹ The argument in a broader context of *Insight* can be outlined as follows: ²⁰

¹⁴ *Ibid.*, 11.

¹⁵ *Id.*, *Insight*, 674.

¹⁶ See *Ibid.*, 674-675.

¹⁷ «Proportionate being» means being proportionate to or knowable by human intelligence.

¹⁸ B. LONERGAN, *Insight*, 695.

¹⁹ *Ibid.*, 696.

²⁰ A more elaborate explanation of this structure: L. ROJKA, *The Eternity of God*, Bratislava (Slovakia), 2005, 111-128.

- (1) We know that at least one real thing (being) exists.
- (2) Real (existing things) is known by intelligent grasp and reasonable / true affirmation.
 - (2a) What can be objectively affirmed as intelligible and existing is being (or a part of being).
- (3) Therefore, existing reality (being) is intelligible.
- (4) Complete intelligibility of being means that being is knowable completely.
 - (4a) Being is known completely if all questions are answered correctly.
 - (4b) Questions are unrestricted (in extent and intent).
 - (4c) There cannot be a meaningful question, which has no answer or explanation.
 - (4d) There are no inexplicable brute facts.
- (5) Therefore, being is completely intelligible.
- (6) Complete intelligibility exists.
- (7) The idea of being (content of understanding) exists.
- (8) Unrestricted act of understanding (God) exists.

The Self-Affirmation

Loneragan delineates the two most important statements of his argument, when he asks where in the process of knowing God's existence makes its implicit entry:

a distinction has to be drawn between (1) affirming a link between other existence and God's and (2) affirming the other existence that is linked to God's existence. The second element lies in the affirmation of some reality: it took place in the chapter on self-affirmation [...]. The first element is the process that identifies the real with being, then identifies being with complete intelligibility, and finally identifies complete intelligibility with the unrestricted act of understanding that possesses the properties of God and accounts for everything else.²¹

The «second element» is the first statement in the argument, and it refers to the person who investigates the intelligibility of reality. A human knower is able to reach true and objective judgment about his own existence. Therefore, reality is somehow knowable and intelligible for human (abstractive) intelligence.

²¹ B. LONERAGAN, *Insight*, 698.

It is important that this first stage of the argument (the self-affirmation) is not omitted. Even though one would get an interesting *a priori* argument starting from an analysis of human knowing (pointing to the desire to know and epistemological exigency of the search for a complete explanation), this is not what Lonergan wanted to do:

Unless we know some reality, there is no possibility of deducing the existence of God. It follows that first we must establish that as a matter of fact we know and that as a matter of fact there is some reality proportionate to our knowing. For only after the facts are known can we entertain any hope of reaching [...] the real as it really is.²²

It is the self-affirmation along with the affirmation of the existence of other proportionate beings, which makes Lonergan's argument most fundamentally cosmological:

The most fundamental of all questions, then, asks about existence, yet neither empirical science nor methodically restricted philosophy can have an adequate answer. [...] In particular cases, the scientist can deduce one existent from others, but not even in particular cases can he account for the existence of the others.²³

Even though Lonergan's cosmological argument starts with the contingent existence, it is not thomistic:

Among Thomists, however, there is a dispute whether *ipsum intelligere* or *ipsum esse subsistens* is logically first among divine attributes. As has been seen in the section on the notion of God, all other divine attributes follow from the notion of an unrestricted act of understanding. Moreover, since we defined being by its relation to intelligence, necessarily our ultimate is not being but intelligence.²⁴

Thus the argument accounts for the existence of the contingences, above all contingency of existence, and concludes with the unrestricted act of understanding. The closest well known argument is Leibniz's cosmological argument of sufficient reason. According to Leibniz, search for a sufficient reason of things and truths cannot be satisfied with efficient or final causes. Only when a ground of intelligibility («self-explained» being) is given, then also sufficient reason of things is given.²⁵

²² *Ibid.*, 701.

²³ *Ibid.*, 676-677.

²⁴ *Ibid.*, 700.

²⁵ G.W. LEIBNIZ, «On the ultimate origination of things (1697)» in Lloyd STRICKLAND (ed.), *The Shorter Leibniz Texts*, London, 2006, 31-38.

The Affirmation of the Complete Intelligibility

Lonergan's reason for the affirmation of the complete intelligibility of reality is that there cannot be inexplicable facts. According to him, an affirmation of inexplicable fact would be meaningless, because «to talk about mere matters of fact that admit no explanation is to talk about nothing. If existence is mere matter of fact, it is nothing. If occurrence is mere matter of fact, it is nothing».²⁶ This «rude and harsh» statement follows from Lonergan's identification of being/reality with reasonably and truly affirmed intelligibility. Lonergan explains: «Being [...] is intelligible, for it is what is to be known by correct understanding; and it is completely intelligible for, being is known completely only when all intelligent questions are answered correctly».²⁷ Once the meaning of «all questions about reality being answered» is grasped, the affirmation of the complete intelligibility should follow.

When Lonergan writes about «questions», he means first of all the metaphysical questions about complete and ultimate explanation of being as a whole (its existence and intelligibility).²⁸ Such transcendental questions «go beyond» sensible experience to uncover the realm, which is conceived absolutely «as the ultimate in the whole process of going beyond».²⁹ One needs to extrapolate here from being «intelligible» for human intelligence, to «intelligible» in general. Anything existing must be intrinsically intelligible. If everything is intelligible, all questions about the proportionate being have adequate answers. Since the proportionate reality is not completely intelligible (it does not provide all the answers), there must be a complete (transcendent) intelligibility which grounds intelligibility of all questions and answers.

From Complete Intelligibility of Reality to God

If all the questions about the multiple («secondary») proportionate intelligibilities are to be answered and adequately explained, then all the intelligibilities must be graspable by an act of understanding, which is not restricted. The affirmation of the possibility of the complete explanation (answering all questions) requires an affirmation of a unique ultimate act of understanding, which

²⁶ B. LONERGAN, *Insight*, 675.

²⁷ *Ibid.*, 695.

²⁸ B. Tyrrell lists some of them: «Why does anything exist?» «Why does anything occur?» «What is the explanation of the contingency, of the virtually unconditioned whose conditions happen to be fulfilled, of what simply happens to be the case?» (B. TYRRELL, *Bernard Lonergan's Philosophy of God*, 125).

²⁹ B. LONERGAN, *Insight*, 658.

explains and grounds this possibility. Since there can only be one such an ultimate unrestricted act, there is only one «idea» (content of its understanding) of all being. In addition, this idea in its ultimate meaning is identical with the intelligibility of the ultimate act. The unrestricted act understands itself (more profound, primary or transcendent intelligibility) and thus it grounds «the explanation of everything about everything else».³⁰ The unrestricted act is one, without any composition (non-material, non-spatial), unconditioned, necessary (in no way contingent), and self-explanatory. Lonergan identifies it with God.

In addition to cognitive unrestrictedness, the primary act of understanding has, according to Lonergan, an absolute perfection, because if there were any sort of imperfection in it, the unrestricted understanding would be restricted.

Consequently, the primary intelligible (by analogy) «is identical not only with an unrestricted act of understanding but also with a completely perfect act of affirming the primary truth and a completely perfect act of loving the primary good».³¹ In its full implications, the primary act must be the first efficient, exemplary and final cause, and the creator of the universe.³² The universe of the proportionate being is neither completely random nor necessary, it is a reasonably realized possibility. It result from a free rational choice which cannot be necessitated, for this would introduce limitation into the unrestricted rational consciousness.

For each statement of this brief summary Lonergan provides a deeper explanation. The method of investigation is his dialectical method: «there is the dialectical unfolding of positions inviting development and counterpositions inciting reversal».³³ In metaphysics, it is «a pure form of the critical attitude». The main criterion of truthfulness is that true theories will call for further explanations, and the untrue theories will involve contradictions and/or inexplicable facts, and thus they will call for reversal. It is this general rule of avoiding obscurantism and contradictions, which is claimed to lead to the affirmation of the unrestricted act.³⁴

The critical method is driven by the pure desire to know. Since many theories will call for reversal, the desire to know must be strong enough to sustain the intellectual conversions (change of positions), if there are good reasons for doing so. It is also important to emphasize that the meaning of the complete intelligibility was derived from the subject's unrestricted desire to know. Nevertheless, the affirmation of God's existence is conditioned neither

³⁰ *Ibid.*, 678.

³¹ *Ibid.*, 681.

³² B. Tyrrell explains at length what it means for an unrestricted act to be exemplary, efficient, and final cause (B. TYRRELL, *Bernard Lonergan's Philosophy of God*, 152-157).

³³ B. LONERGAN, *CWL 03 (Insight)*, 427.

³⁴ See *Ibid.*, 708.

by its actual fulfillment nor by the real possibility of its fulfillment in future (we may not reach the state of all questions being answered). Human knowing is limited, conceptual and abstractive, and therefore, its fulfillment cannot be identified with the reach of the primary intelligibility. Yet, the goal of the pure desire to know is the reach of the primary intelligibility, the state of knowing everything about everything.

The Validity of the Argument

Since we have only very briefly summarized the basic terminology, structure, and principles involved in Lonergan's argument for the existence of God, let us consider a few objections to its validity, which will help us to explicate better the principles involved.

Let us start with slightly different interpretations of his argument. Gary Schouborg wants to show that the argument is not *a priori*, but that it has its experiential ground. He outlined Lonergan's argument in a form of a deductive argument, but at the end he acknowledges that his short article «can hardly be a sufficient exposition» of showing its validity.³⁵

Ruben Habito, in his comparison of L. Dewart and B. Lonergan, elaborates the idea that Lonergan made a valid *transcendental* argument in the sense that is «is based on a scholastic appropriation of the transcendental method of Kant, but is an attempt to go beyond the latter».³⁶ Habito distinguishes well «the heuristic structure for determining the attributes of God»³⁷, mediation of the concept of the unrestricted act, and a proof that such an act really exists. He explains the proof as follows:

Lonergan implies that the activity aimed at satisfying man's desire to know, [...] presupposes that the desire which is unrestricted can be ultimately fulfilled, or else the individual act of knowing, the individual insight gained, have no real foundation. He therefore equates the acceptance of the minor premise with the acceptance of man's own intelligence and reasonableness as valid guides for the unrestricted desire to know: the unrestricted desire calls for an unrestricted fulfillment, otherwise it would be an absurd, aimless and untrustworthy desire. To deny that such a fulfillment can be had would seem to imply the denial of one's own intelligence and reasonableness, and since this implies a self-contradiction, the affirmation of the minor premise can follow.³⁸

³⁵ G. SCHOUBORG, «A Note on Lonergan's Argument for the Existence of God» in *The Modern Schoolman* 45 (1968) 243.

³⁶ R. L. HABITO, «A Catholic Debate on God: Dewart and Lonergan» in *Philippine Studies* 18/3 (1970) 561, note 8.

³⁷ *Ibid.*, 562.

³⁸ *Ibid.*, 563-564.

A valid guide for the desire to know is provided by human intelligence, and all dynamism of knowing would be absurd without the possibility of fulfillment in complete intelligibility. Complete intelligibility provides real foundation for individual insights reached through the desire to know. The denial of complete intelligibility is a denial of something crucial in human knower. Habito also emphasizes the relation of the transcendent to personal integrity: «to be truly a man means to keep on striving to transcend oneself, towards greater possession of truth and goodness. To reject transcendence is to reject striving for and the possibility of fulfillment, and is thus to be less a man».³⁹

To summarize, Habito proposes two reasons for the affirmation of the unrestricted act: First, the unrestricted desire would be absurd / unexplained without transcendent being. It calls for an explanation. Second, the denial of transcendent being means a performative self-contradiction with what we intend in knowing. Performative self-contradiction defense (sometimes called «retor-sion») is supposed to guarantee the validity of the argument.

Patricia Wilson considers Lonergan's theory a version of «Maréchal Thomism», in which, quoting Lotz, «the proof of God's existence is somehow pre-contained in the orientation of the human intellect towards being».⁴⁰ After her analysis of human desire to know, she concludes:

Although man is always seeking absolute knowledge of being, he can never affirm that he possesses it. The only possible explanation for such striving is that there is an absolute being which is the ground and the foundation of all this striving. (If there is no such being, then there is really not an explanation, since the intellectual dynamism of man is doomed to frustration, and reality is unintelligible.)⁴¹

According to Wilson, without the complete intelligibility there would be no explanation for the dynamism of human mind towards absolute knowledge. The inner dynamics of intending which is the basis of the process of coming to know, demands the infinite horizon.⁴² Interestingly, she adds that if there were no complete intelligibility, reality would not be intelligible at all. She wants to strengthen the argument not with a performative self-contradiction, but emphasizing the contradiction between the affirmation of the intelligibility of reality and the denial of the complete intelligibility:

³⁹ *Ibid.*, 568.

⁴⁰ P. WILSON, «Human Knowledge of God's Existence in the Theology of Bernard Lonergan» in *The Thomist* vol. XXXV, no. 2 (1971) 259. Quoted article: J.B. Lotz, «Immanuel Kant» in *New Catholic Encyclopedia*, vol. 8, New York, 1967, 127.

⁴¹ P. WILSON, «Human Knowledge of God's Existence», 263.

⁴² See *Ibid.*, 272.

If one asserts the intelligibility of being, one must assert its complete intelligibility. Something which is not really known by at least someone in fact is not really intelligible. But, if there is only finite knowing, then something always remains unknown, since the infinite horizon of possible questions can never be comprehended by a finite knower, and thus there must be an infinite and unrestricted knower who in fact knows and comprehends all proportionate being.⁴³

Wilson's explanation rests on the principle that every intelligibility must be known by somebody.

Dorothy Emmet also emphasizes dynamic orientation towards the transcendent operative in our thinking, but in a different way:

if being is intelligible, the «an unrestricted act of understanding exists», and this he [Lonergan] takes to be not only what Kant would have called a regulative ideal towards which our always limited thinking aspires, but something already existing in its own right which can be called God. The drive towards this is a principle constitutive for our thinking.⁴⁴

The drive towards the complete intelligibility existing «in its own right» is constitutive for our thinking. On this interpretation, the denial of the complete intelligibility does not imply a performative self-contradiction, just that the drive would have no real explanation / foundation.

Ronald Hepburn gives his reasons against Kantian transcendental interpretation of Lonergan's argument, which are also against transcendental performative self-contradiction interpretation. He states that Lonergan's argument provides a valuable regulative ideal, but if taken as transcendental, then it is not valid: «The notion of complete intelligibility in explanation [...] can be seen as a valuable ideal, a regulative notion that extends or extrapolates from our experience of *limited* intelligibility; it cannot claim, however, to be a *condition* for the possibility of any explanation».⁴⁵ More precisely,

the notion of the complete intelligibility of the world is an extension of, or extrapolation from, our successful attempts to understand aspects of the world. It is not a condition of our having any knowledge at all, nor a condition of our having the knowledge we do have. Only if it were a condition could a valid transcendental argument be mounted.⁴⁶

⁴³ *Ibid.*, , 270.

⁴⁴ D. EMMET, «The Double Conversion of Bernard Lonergan and Karl Rahner» in *Theoria to theory* 7/2 (1973) 13.

⁴⁵ R. HEPBURN, «Transcendental Method: Lonergan's Arguments for the Existence of God» in *Theoria to theory* 7/3 (1973) 50.

⁴⁶ *Ibid.*, 49.

Hepburn is right that one can reach objective knowledge without believing or implying complete intelligibility of reality. Complete intelligibility is not constitutive for our knowledge. Nevertheless, it is constitutive to the pure desire to know and to the dynamism of searching always a better explanation. Any limited explanation is not satisfactory for pure desire to know. The past success does not explain why we are not satisfied with it any more, and why we always want a better explanation. The notion of complete intelligibility helps to explicate the goal of a pure, unrestricted desire to know. Yet, such a goal or explanation, or a condition of meaningfulness, does not prove the real existence of the complete intelligibility.

B.C. Butler proposed a different interpretation. He explains Lonergan's «extrapolations» in terms of converging probabilities: «The procedure is quite unlike a classical syllogism. It is more like what Newman has to tell us about converging probabilities. Newman was prepared to say that, in some circumstances, converging probabilities could lead to a conclusion that was certain».⁴⁷ On this interpretation, the argument could be certain, even not deductively valid.

In my understanding, Lonergan did not use the above transcendental defense to prove the existence of God. In *Insight*, he used the intentionality analysis and the analysis of the unrestricted desire to know to give meaning to the concept of the unrestricted understanding (which is the goal of the desire). Complete intelligibility is somehow operative in the pure desire to know (not necessarily in a skeptic's mind). Lonergan defended the fourfold human structure with the method of performative self-contradiction, but not the affirmation of the complete intelligibility. In the argument he «extrapolates» from the intelligibility of the know reality to the intelligibility of the proportionate being, and then to the complete intelligibility of all being. In a sense, he used the method of searching the best explanation (which he calls «position») and refusing the other («counter-positions»). The counter positions denying God necessarily involve, according to Lonergan, contradictions and / or affirmation of brute facts. This is why they are not satisfactory for human intelligence. But the fact that inexplicable facts are not satisfactory for human intelligence does not prove that reality is completely intelligible and that God exists. In order to use an *a priori* principle, one needs to show logical impossibility that there cannot be coherent «theories of everything» (in which all questions have an explanation) without God. Some modern physicists believe that they have found a «key», which leads to a single all-embracing picture of all the laws of nature from which all things follow. We will return to this problem at the end of the next section.

⁴⁷ B.C. BUTLER, «God: Anticipation and Affirmation» in *The Heythrop Journal* 20/4 (1979) 368.

Critical Realist «Meta-Proof»

In addition to the foregoing discussions about the validity of Lonergan's argument, there have been debates about its deeper nature. Quentin Quesnell argues against Frederick Crowe, Hugo Meynell, and William Wainwright that the argument is neither ontological (he means «from definitions») nor cosmological (from experience of complete intelligibility), but a critical realist «meta-proof».⁴⁸ He summarizes the entire proof based on the notion of being: «Lonergan writes in the conviction that all human beings already have knowledge of God, just as all have implicit knowledge of being and of self. His proof offers the tools to make their knowledge of God explicit».⁴⁹ The subject has a notion of being (of complete intelligibility) at the beginning and then he explicates this notion into a fully developed concept of the complete intelligibility of being and reality of God. When Quesnell tries to be more specific, he says that Lonergan's argument moves from «I, who am seriously trying to understand the world, cannot doubt that the world is understandable» to the realization: «I already hold that God exists».⁵⁰ In order to recognize these statements as true, objective, and certain, one has to assimilate Chapters 11, 12, and 13 of *Insight* (chapters on self-affirmation, notion of being and objectivity).

Q. Quesnell seems to miss Lonergan's distinction of giving meaning to the concept of God and an argument that God really exists. He explicates how the meaning of the unrestricted act is generated based on Lonergan's analysis of the pure desire to know, and of the notion of being and objectivity.

Bernard Tyrrell (1974), who according to J. Kanaris made «a definitive study»⁵¹ of Lonergan's argument, makes this interpretation even more straightforward: «it is only if one intelligently, critically and wholeheartedly commits oneself to the positions [...] that it will ultimately be possible critically to validate for oneself the legitimacy of Lonergan's formal proof for the existence of God. Indeed, [...] nothing less is required of the individual than an 'unrestricted commitment to complete intelligibility'».⁵² This statement explicates apparent circularity of this thought: one is first committed to the complete intelligibility (of positions), and then he affirms that it really exists. One would naturally expect a good reason to believe that reality is completely intelligible, and then, if affirmative, he can make his commitment to the basic intuition he has. It is quite unusual to ask for such a personal commitment of the reader as part of an argument.

⁴⁸ Q. QUESNELL, «What Kind of Proof is *Insight* 19?» in F. LAWRENCE (ed.), *Lonergan Workshop* 8, Atlanta, 1990, 276-277.

⁴⁹ *Ibid.*, 276.

⁵⁰ *Ibid.*, 274.

⁵¹ J. KANARIS, *Bernard Lonergan's Philosophy of Religion*, 15.

⁵² B. TYRRELL, *Bernard Lonergan's Philosophy of God*, 121.

This may sound like an argument *ad hominem*, which ultimately is not an argument at all, and authentic (self-transcending) knower has to refute it, because it is not objective. B. Tyrrell (and Q. Quesnell in the last quote) probably wanted to emphasize the initial commitment to (absolute) objectivity and self-transcendence (not to what appears, but «what is really so») and not the commitment to complete intelligibility. The commitment to objectivity implies neither the commitment to, nor a proof of the complete intelligibility. Many scientists are committed to the search of objectively validated theories without implicitly or explicitly affirming the complete intelligibility of reality.

David Burrell⁵³ argues that Lonergan's basic attempt to extrapolate from the restricted to the unrestricted act of understanding is an impossible endeavor. His first objection is that «we simply cannot affirm that being is completely intelligible because we cannot conceive what the judgment would be like which affirmed that all intelligent questions were in and all answered correctly».⁵⁴ Lonergan answers that one must advert not to knowing but to intending: «a conscious intending of an unknown that is to be known».⁵⁵ Tyrrell tries to elaborate this answer further:

It can be shown (1) that man intends complete intelligibility, (2) that the intention of complete intelligibility is "at the root of all our attempts to mean anything at all", (3) that to impugn the unrestricted character of our intending is to undermine at its core the source of all human knowing, and (4) that man can and does ask strategic questions about the meaning of being, etc., and does arrive at critically validated heuristic answers.⁵⁶

A simpler answer to Burrell's objection is that we can conceive what the judgment, which affirms that all intelligent questions are answered correctly, would be like. It is the same «judgment» as the grasp the intelligibility of a function, equation, or a law of nature, in the case of which we also cannot reach all the instances of possible applications, and yet, we know that they are true. We can have a conception of an unrestricted act, even without a grasp of all the intelligibilities. Nonetheless, the difficulty is that even if we can conceive complete intel-

⁵³ D. BURRELL, «How Complete Can Intelligibility be?» in *Proceedings of the American Catholic Philosophical Association* 49 (1967).

⁵⁴ *Ibid.*, 252.

⁵⁵ B. LONERGAN, « Response to Father Burrell » in *Proceedings of the American Catholic Philosophical Association* 49 (1967) 258. Lonergan also says that «since intending is just another name for meaning, it follows that complete intelligibility [...] is in fact at the root of all our attempts to mean anything at all» (*Ibid.*, 259).

⁵⁶ B. TYRRELL, *Bernard Lonergan's Philosophy of God*, 172.

ligibility coherently, and we accept that complete intelligibility is implied in the dynamism of human knowing, based on Lonergan's conception of objectivity, we need an additional proof that complete intelligibility is not only intended, desired, and coherently conceived in human intellect, but that it really exists.

The second Burrell's objection is as follows: «how then, when the unrestricted act lacks this very focal point, the judgment, can we pretend to extrapolate to it from the properties of a restricted act?»⁵⁷ Tyrrell responds:

If, then, a perfect instance of knowing could be realized in which the knower and the known were identical not only intentionally but in being, then understanding alone would suffice for knowledge of the reality of the known and the addition of judgment would be simply superfluous. In other words, in this perfect instance of knowing, the act of understanding in the very act of its grasping itself would suffice to fulfill the functions of both understanding and judging as they occur in human knowing. [...] All that judgment positively implies in human knowing is eminently realized in God as the unrestricted act of understanding.⁵⁸

This statement answers not only Burrell's objection, but also objections raised by many other philosophers, for whom the concept of self-explanatory being is incoherent.⁵⁹ However, in order to avoid misunderstanding, it seems better to speak of the intelligible ground of all our explanations (answers and questions), than of a self-explanatory being. There are really no explanations (no conceptual thinking) in an unrestricted act of understanding.

In overall, the structure of Lonergan's arguments is «critically validated» (Tyrrell) at least in the sense that it is meaningful and coherent. The notion of complete intelligibility is operative in the pure desire to know and it can be coherently defined. This does not prove yet, that being as a whole is completely intelligible implying the existence of God. An additional argument, which justifies the last extrapolation (to transcendent being) of Lonergan's argument is needed. An appeal to the complete intelligibility and God in order to explain our strive for full meaning and knowledge would have to face competing evolutionary theories. One can expect that scientists will propose a «*cui bono?*» expla-

⁵⁷ B. BURRELL, «How Complete Can Intelligibility be?», 253.

⁵⁸ B. TYRRELL, *Bernard Lonergan's Philosophy of God*, 173.

⁵⁹ For instance: «[I]t is logically impossible to explain *everything*. In any explanation, whatever is to be explained (the *explanandum*) is accounted for by whatever explains it (the *explanans*). In order for the *explanandum* to be explained by the *explanans*, the latter must, at least for the moment, go unexplained. [...] However far we go in our chain of explanations, something will always be unexplained. This is a necessary feature of the logic of explanations. However, this in no ways indicates that our explanations of things are at all inadequate» (K. M. PARSONS, *God and the Burden of Proof*, Buffalo [N.Y.], 1989, 66).

nation of the unrestricted desire. A transcendental performative self-contradiction defense does not provide a conclusive argument either, for the reasons explained in the previous section.

In *Insight*, Lonergan proposed an assessment of the *a priori* impossibility of the real existence of inexplicable facts. In other words, a «theory of really everything» without God (transcendent intelligibility) is logically impossible. In addition to the fact that it is not satisfactory for human intelligence, it is also objectively inconceivable for human mind, and thus it cannot be true. This *a priori* statement seems to be at the heart of his cosmological argument. The incompleteness of explanations of reality in terms of contingent being is most obvious in the most fundamental questions regarding the existence of the contingent entities. Of course, the justifications of the previous section, in so far as they are reasonable (even though not conclusive), can make the argument more effective. One could also add inductive support (as Butler suggested) from the debates about the «theories of everything». For instance, J. Barrow in his most recent book shows that the proposed «theories of everything» are by no means sufficient for a complete understanding of the universe, despite such claims by several scientists.⁶⁰

Conclusion

The goal of this paper was to shortly present Lonergan's reasoning about the existence of God and its role in the context of his explanation of personal integrity. Even though the arguments are intended to convince people and make a change in human society, they can do so insofar as people are reasonable and authentic. If the existence of God could not be objectively justified, religion and theology would become somehow superfluous, and human decision to believe in God would be objectively and critically groundless. If an argument is not interesting for somebody, this does not mean that the argument is not good.

It has been concluded that Lonergan's argument is fundamentally a sort of Leibnizian cosmological argument from the contingency of proportionate being to the unrestricted understanding. Both, the principle that each and every question has an answer (explanation) and the notion of complete intelligibility, are somehow operative in the dynamism of authentic human knowing. They are also important in order to make the concept of an unrestricted act (God) meaningful.

⁶⁰ J.D. BARROW, *New Theories of Everything*, Oxford, 2007.

Examination of the validity of the argument has brought to light several crucial principles important for the question of God: The importance of the authentic human desire to know and openness to the search for a complete and objective explanation of all being. It is important to search for a «theory of really everything». A non-dogmatic and unbiased knower does not dismiss the overall metaphysical questions about the universe as meaningless without a good reason. Once the questions are accepted and the answers are critically examined, Lonergan believed, the affirmation of the unrestricted act of understanding and its identification with God are unavoidable.

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SUMMARY

Although B. Lonergan realized that contemporary culture tends to render scholastic (or conceptualist) philosophy irrelevant, he states that organized systems profoundly affect a culture. Development is through specialization and integration. Lonergan's philosophy of God has two stages. The first Lonergan emphasizes philosophical theology (the concept and the arguments for the existence of God) and the second, philosophy of religion (religious experience, conversion, cultural traditions). The philosophical theology of *Insight* (1957) is unfinished. Several authors tried to elaborate further Lonergan's conception, some of them unsuccessfully. Nevertheless, several important features of his philosophical theology emerge: the value of the arguments for a culture, the crucial role of the pure desire to know in giving meaning to his concept of God, the epistemological requirement of the search for a complete explanation of reality, and the refusal of any obscurantism (inexplicable facts).

Benché B. Lonergan realizzò che la cultura contemporanea tendeva a considerare la filosofia scolastica (o concettualistica) irrilevante, egli mostrò quanto i sistemi coerenti, il cui sviluppo si fa mediante la specializzazione e l'integrazione, affettino profondamente una cultura. La filosofia di Lonergan su Dio conosce due momenti: il primo si concentra sulla teologia filosofica (il concetto e gli argomenti a favore dell'esistenza di Dio) e il secondo sulla filosofia della religione (l'esperienza religiosa, la conversione, le tradizioni culturali). La teologia filosofica di *Insight* (1957) è incompiuta. Parecchi autori tentano di elaborare una concezione lonerganiana più profonda, alcuni di essi senza successo. Molte caratteristiche della sua filosofia teologica rimangono però essenziali: il valore dell'argomento per la cultura, il ruolo cruciale del puro desiderio di conoscere che dà significato al concetto di Dio, le esigenze epistemologiche della ricerca in vista di una esplorazione completa della realtà e il rifiuto di ogni oscurantismo (i fatti inesplorabili).